



MZUZU UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF OPTOMETRY

MANUAL FOR OPTOMETRY PRECEPTORS

A guide to successful clinical placement

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Preface by the Head of Department

Dear Colleagues and Esteemed Preceptors,

As the Head of the Department of Optometry, it gives me immense pleasure to present to you this comprehensive manual, a resource meticulously designed to enhance the clinical training of our future optometrists. This guide is not just a collection of protocols and guidelines; it represents our collective commitment to excellence in optometric education and patient care.

In the ever-evolving landscape of healthcare and eye care, the role of clinical education remains pivotal. It bridges the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical expertise, shaping students into professionals capable of meeting the diverse needs of our communities. This manual, therefore, is a cornerstone in this transformative process. It offers a structured framework for our preceptors, equipping them with the tools and insights needed to guide our students effectively through their clinical journey.

Our aim is not just to maintain the high standards of clinical practice but to elevate them. Each section of this manual has been carefully crafted to address the multifaceted aspects of clinical training – from student orientation to ethical practices, from patient care to feedback mechanisms. By standardizing these practices across our clinical sites, we ensure a uniformly excellent learning experience for all our students, irrespective of their placement location.

I urge you to embrace this manual not just as a set of instructions, but as a beacon guiding our path towards nurturing competent, ethical, and compassionate optometrists. Your role as preceptors is invaluable. You are not just teaching clinical skills; you are mentoring the next generation of eye care professionals who will make significant contributions to public health.

Together, let's embark on this journey of continuous improvement and excellence. Let's commit to not only imparting knowledge and skills but also inspiring our students to uphold the highest standards of professional integrity and patient care.

Thank you for your dedication, expertise, and continued support in shaping the future of optometry.

Sincerely,

Joseph C Afonne
Head of the Department of Optometry

1.0 Introduction

Welcome to this foundational guide, crafted to ensure excellence and uniformity in clinical training for optometry students across various placement sites. This guide acts as a pivotal tool for preceptors, facilitating the delivery of a high-caliber clinical education and driving the advancement of student experiences in real-world settings. It is designed to support every student's path to clinical proficiency, offering a detailed and consistent framework that nurtures ongoing growth and outstanding clinical performance.

The journey through clinical placement is a critical phase in optometry education, transforming theoretical knowledge into practical, hands-on skills essential in eye care. This period is instrumental in exposing students to diverse ocular conditions and integrating them into the professional community. It sharpens their patient communication skills, deepens their understanding through practical feedback, and helps shape their specialization within optometry. Within this real-world context, the manual ensures students are rigorously prepared to meet the high standards of the optometry profession and provide compassionate, patient-centered care upon entering the workforce.

Preceptors, as central figures in this educational process, play a multifaceted role that goes beyond supervision. They are mentors, educators, and role models, diligently guiding students through the nuances of patient care. Their supervision guarantees patient safety and the high quality of care, while their feedback and evaluation are instrumental in the professional development of the students. As advocates of student learning and upholders of professional standards, preceptors are crucial in shaping students into skilled, ethical practitioners equipped to serve as leaders in eye health.

Section 1: Student Arrival at the Placement Centre

Expectations for Students Upon Arrival

Setting clear initial expectations is crucial for a smooth transition into clinical placement:

- Students should arrive punctually, dressed professionally, and prepared for an orientation session.
- They are expected to exhibit a proactive attitude, demonstrating eagerness to learn and adapt to the new environment.
- Students must understand and commit to upholding patient confidentiality and the clinic's code of conduct from the outset.

Standard Procedure for Student Check-In

A systematic check-in process ensures that all students start on equal footing:

- Implement a sign-in sheet or electronic check-in system to track student attendance.
- Provide students with identification badges and any necessary access codes or keys.
- Orient students to their designated locker or storage areas for personal belongings.

Introduction to the Clinical Environment and Staff

A thorough introduction to the clinic sets the stage for a successful placement:

- Conduct a guided tour of the clinic, pointing out key areas such as the reception, examination rooms, and equipment stations.
- Introduce the students to clinic staff and any other personnel they will be working with closely.
- Explain the clinic's patient flow, including the process from patient check-in to check-out.
- Review emergency procedures and the location of safety equipment on the first day.

By carefully organizing the arrival and orientation process, students are set up for success in their clinical education journey.

Section 2: Orientation of Students by Preceptors

Specific Knowledge and Skills

To ensure a robust foundation for clinical practice, the orientation must cover critical knowledge and skills:

- Introduce diagnostic and therapeutic equipment usage, including hands-on demonstrations.
- Review patient interaction protocols and effective communication strategies.
- Detailed routine eye examination steps and the process for more complex diagnostic procedures.
- Demonstrate the use of the electronic medical records system and the importance of accurate documentation.
- Discuss clinic emergency procedures, infection control, and the management of adverse events.
- Emphasize the assessment of refractive errors, ocular health evaluations, and management plans for common ocular conditions.

Materials and Resources

A well-prepared orientation requires an array of materials and resources for optimal learning:

- Provide clinic manuals and procedural guidelines for reference.
- Supply equipment manuals and quick-reference guides for all clinical instruments.
- Grant access to online learning modules and instructional videos that cover key optometric procedures.
- Arrange for observation sessions with seasoned practitioners to facilitate experiential learning.
- Compile a list of scheduled patient appointments to assist students in understanding the workflow.

Clinic's Protocols and Patient Care Standards

The orientation should meticulously address the clinic's protocols and the high standards of patient care to be upheld:

- Clarify the clinic's standard operating procedures, including protocols for patient confidentiality and informed consent.
- Reinforce the adherence to legal and professional standards in the delivery of patient care services.
- Highlight the clinic's commitment to ethical practice and the provision of equitable patient care.
- Guide students through patient care pathways, from initial assessment to follow-up care.
- Ensure students are aware of the expectations for patient interactions and the quality of care provided.

By following this structured approach, the orientation will equip students with the necessary tools and understanding to navigate the clinical environment successfully.

Section 3: Day-to-Day Clinical Supervision

Daily Supervisory Responsibilities

Effective supervision is critical for student development and patient care quality:

- Monitor students' clinical work to ensure adherence to established standards and protocols.
- Ensure a supportive learning environment where students feel comfortable asking questions and seeking guidance.
- Verify that students are conducting examinations and procedures correctly and safely.
- Manage the balance between student learning opportunities and efficient clinic operation.
- Provide immediate, on-the-spot feedback to students as they perform clinical tasks.

Facilitating Student Learning and Patient Engagement

Preceptors play a vital role in enhancing student-patient interactions:

- Model exemplary patient communication and care, allowing students to learn by example.
- Encourage students to take active roles in patient interactions under close supervision.
- Set up opportunities for students to observe a variety of patient cases, fostering a broader learning experience.
- Facilitate discussions post-patient encounters to reflect on the clinical experience and learning points.
- Continually assess and adjust teaching methods to cater to individual student learning styles.

Best Practices for a Productive Learning Environment

Maintaining a conducive learning atmosphere is essential for student growth:

- Establish a respectful, collaborative, and non-intimidating learning space.
- Develop clear expectations and objectives for students to achieve during their placement.
- Utilize constructive criticism and positive reinforcement to motivate students.
- Encourage students to engage in self-directed learning and to utilize available resources.
- Promote peer learning and teamwork among students to enhance collaborative skills.

By taking these steps, preceptors ensure that the clinical placement is not only a chance to develop practical skills, but also a foundation for professional conduct and patient care ethics.

Section 4: Providing Constructive Feedback

Effective Feedback Methods

Delivering feedback is an art that enhances learning and performance:

- Utilize the "sandwich" method by starting with positive feedback, addressing areas for improvement, and concluding with encouragement.
- Offer specific, behavior-based feedback that students can act upon rather than general comments.
- Engage in real-time feedback whenever possible to reinforce learning in the context in which it is applied.
- Encourage a two-way dialogue where students can ask questions and discuss feedback points for clarity.
- Use direct observation and evidence from student performances to provide concrete examples.

Frequency of Feedback

Regular feedback is essential to the learning process:

- Provide immediate feedback following clinical encounters to address performance while it's still fresh.
- Schedule regular weekly sessions for more comprehensive feedback and discussion of progress.
- Ensure that there is a feedback component in every supervised clinical session to reinforce continuous learning.
- Make use of periodic formal assessments to give structured, in-depth feedback at key points in the clinical placement.

Structuring Feedback for Reflection and Growth

Feedback should be a tool for self-improvement and reflection:

- Frame feedback in a way that encourages students to self-assess and identify their own areas for improvement.
- Develop action plans together with students, setting clear and achievable goals for development.
- Incorporate reflective practices such as keeping a journal or logbook where students can note feedback and their reflections on it.
- Use guided questioning to help students analyze their performance and internalize lessons learned.
- Encourage students to set their own objectives for the next clinical session based on the feedback received.

Through these strategies, feedback becomes a powerful catalyst for student growth, fostering a reflective approach to clinical practice and continuous self-improvement.

Section 5: Clinical Assessment Organization

Sourcing Patients for Assessments

Securing a diverse patient base is key for comprehensive student assessments:

- Collaborate with other colleagues to identify patients willing to participate in student assessments.
- Develop a database of patients with a variety of ocular conditions to ensure broad exposure for students.
- Utilize patient databases responsibly to maintain a steady flow of suitable assessment candidates, adhering to privacy regulations.
- Ensuring students are not privy to the assessment patients or their conditions
- Encourage students to participate in community outreach programs, which can also serve as a source of patients for assessments.

Preparation and Management of Assessment Equipment

Effective assessment requires appropriate and well-maintained equipment:

- Review the assessment plan in advance to identify all necessary equipment and ensure its availability.
- Arrange for the equipment to be set up and calibrated before the assessments begin.
- In cases where specific equipment is not readily available, promptly request these items from the MZUNI Optometry department.
- Ensure that all equipment is in good working order and that any malfunctions are addressed prior to use.
- Provide students with a brief training or refresher on the use of any specialized or complex equipment they will encounter during assessments.

Arrangement of Assessment Schedule

A well-organized schedule is fundamental for an effective assessment process:

- Create a structured timetable that allows students sufficient time with each patient for a thorough assessment while managing clinic traffic efficiently.
- Ensure that the schedule accounts for different levels of student proficiency, providing more complex cases as their skills advance.
- Integrate time for pre-assessment preparation and post-assessment discussion within the schedule.

Preceptor Role During Assessments

Preceptors are pivotal in overseeing and enriching the assessment experience:

- Observe students during assessments to provide a safety net for both the patient and the student.

- Gauge student performance objectively, stepping in when necessary to ensure the standard of care is maintained.
- Facilitate a debriefing session where students can reflect on their performance and identify learning opportunities.
- Preceptors will not share students' specific grades with them, but they will be able to discuss their performance on the assessment tasks during the debriefing session.

These practices will ensure that students receive a balanced and realistic experience of clinical assessments, preparing them for future independent practice.

Section 6: Handling Log Books and Reporting

Utilization of Log Books by Students

Log books are essential for tracking clinical progress and experiences:

- Instruct students to record each clinical encounter in detail, ensuring the log book is updated regularly, ideally immediately after patient interactions.
- Emphasize the importance of consistency and accuracy in logging clinical activities, which can serve as a tool for self-reflection and assessment.
- Train students on how to protect patient privacy while keeping comprehensive records.

Crucial Log Book Entries

Detailed and precise entries are the backbone of an effective log book:

- Record patient demographics and present complaints while maintaining confidentiality.
- Note the clinical procedures performed, observations made, and the outcomes of each encounter.
- Include reflections on clinical experiences, highlighting any learning points or questions that arose.
- Document feedback received from preceptors and any steps taken towards improvement.

Preceptor Review and Sign-off

Preceptor involvement is key to validating the student's clinical experiences:

- Schedule regular intervals for reviewing student log books to confirm the accuracy and authenticity of entries.
- Provide a signature or a unique sign-off to endorse the student's recorded experiences, signifying verification and approval.
- Offer constructive feedback on the log book entries, pointing out areas well-documented and those needing improvement.

Addressing Discrepancies and Concerns

A clear process for handling log book issues ensures integrity:

- Establish a protocol for students to follow if they need to correct or update log book entries.

- Create a system for reporting and discussing any discrepancies or concerns related to log book entries with the preceptor.
- Ensure that any changes made to the log book after preceptor review are clearly noted and justified.

By adhering to these structured guidelines, log books can be utilized effectively, serving as a reliable record of clinical learning and a reflective tool for student development.

Steps For Use of The Log Book and Attachment Report Writing by The Students

The logbook for optometry students is a tool that allows them to conduct a well-documented and comprehensive clinical evaluation during their attachment. The logbook records all activities performed by the student, the doctor/intern/supervisor during the attachment period, and also allows the student to comprehensively and carefully perform and report all clinical activities.

The log book document is in 3 parts:

Part 1: Guidelines for writing and submission of clinical attachment report

Part 2: Clinical attachment assessment Form for assessment by the Supervisor from Mzuni, Hospital/clinic supervisor/in-charge and the student.

Part 3: Clinical attachment activities Log book

Step 1: Preparations

- Print, arrange and NEATLY bind (Tape binding is preferable) the entire document
- Take the document for endorsement by the attachment coordinator
- Read, familiarize, assimilate and master the guidelines and instruction on filling the document.

Step 2: Filling the attachment log book

- Ensure that the Doctor/clinic supervisor/examiner duly fill the section “Feedback on students’ performance”.
- Ensure that as a student, you duly, truthfully and transparently fill the section “Students feedback form”.
- Ensure that the Doctor/Clinical Supervisor duly fill, signs and put the establishment stamp on the session “Clinical Attachment Clearance Form”.
- Observe the stated guidelines for marking/scoring “Guidelines for marking clinical attachment report”. (For the Doctor/Clinic supervisor/examiner Only).
- Ensure that the Doctor/Clinic supervisor/examiner duly fills as demanded, tick as required and Record as provided and compute the scores in the “Summary of Scores” section.

Please note that your attachment grade/score/mark will be partly determined by this section. The minimum grade/score/mark is 0, and the maximum grade/score/mark is 65.

Step 3: Attachment report writing

- In accordance with the Daily/end of Week attachment activities, write your daily clinical activities report and also the reflection of the day and end of week – clinical attachment Activities summary/Reflection in a complete, clear, transparent, and ethical manner.
- Ensure that both Doctor/clinic supervisor/examiner and students signs the log book, daily and weekly as provided (Part 3: Clinical attachment activities log book)
- Ensure that you compile your attachment report as instructed (Daily, daily reflections, Weekly. See Part 1: Guidelines for writing and submission of clinical attachment report of the attachment booklet.
- Add extra paper if the provided space is not enough while writing the attachment daily and end of week report/reflections.
- Reports written separately, should be **NEATLY** bound (Tape binding is preferable).
- Submit your attachment report not more than one week from the end of the attachment day as directed.
- Document should be submitted through the secretary of the department of Optometry, Faculty of health sciences. **The task must be completed within one week of the end of the attached document.**

Please note that your attachment's grade/score/mark is partially based on the following section: Report. The grade/score/mark for this section is 100. Please see the score sheet in the last section of part 1 of the document for more information.

Section 7: Ethical and Professional Standards

Ethical Considerations in Supervision

Preceptors must embody and impart the core values of the optometric profession:

- Maintain patient confidentiality at all times and instruct students on how to handle sensitive information.
- Model impartial and unbiased care by treating all patients with respect, regardless of background or health status.
- Ensure that informed consent is obtained and students understand its importance in clinical practice.
- Address any ethical dilemmas or conflicts of interest that arise, using them as teaching moments for ethical decision-making.

- Uphold academic integrity, encouraging students to be honest about their abilities and uncertainties.

Communicating and Enforcing Professional Standards

Clear articulation and demonstration of professional standards are critical for student development:

- Regularly discuss the code of ethics and the standards of professional practice with students.
- Demonstrate professionalism in all interactions with patients, colleagues, and students to serve as a role model.
- Implement a zero-tolerance policy for breaches of professional conduct, providing clear consequences for such actions.
- Use role-play and scenario-based learning to teach students how to handle various professional challenges.
- Encourage self-regulation and the internalization of professional standards through reflective exercises and discussions.

By following these guidelines, preceptors ensure that ethical and professional standards are not only communicated but also instilled in the practice and mindset of future optometrists.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this manual serves as a comprehensive guide for preceptors, outlining the essential roles and responsibilities in the clinical training of optometry students. Through its structured sections, it aims to standardize practices across different clinical settings, ensuring that students receive a consistent, high-quality educational experience. By adhering to the guidelines presented, preceptors will be well-equipped to mentor and guide the next generation of optometrists, fostering their growth into competent, ethical, and compassionate professionals. The collaboration between students, preceptors, and clinical settings, as detailed in this manual, is fundamental to the advancement of optometric care and the continuous improvement of eye health services. Let us embrace these guidelines with a shared commitment to excellence and a unified vision for the future of optometry.

Appendices

- Sample log book page
- Assessment forms and checklists
- Contact information for academic liaison